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School of Engineering

Title of Work

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A dissertation submitted in partial fulfilment
of the requirements for the degree of
MAI (XXXXXX Engineering)

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Abstract

A short summary of the problem investigated, the approach taken and the key findings. This should not be more than around 400 words.

This must be on a separate page.

Lay Abstract

Similar to the actual abstract in terms of the information, but written for a non-specialist. So no jargon, no acronyms. Explain to a member of the general public what this project entailed. Should be no longer than the actual abstract.

This must be on a separate page.

Acknowledgements

Thanks Everyone!

You should acknowledge any help that you have received (for example from technical staff), or input provided by, for example, a company.

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Nomenclature

A	Area of the wing	m^2
B		
C	Roman letters first, with capitals. . .	
a	then lower case.	
b		
c		
Γ	Followed by Greek capitals. . .	
α	then lower case greek symbols.	
β		
ε		
TLA	Finally, three letter acronyms and other abbreviations arranged alphabetically	

If a parameter has a typical unit that is used throughout your report, then it should be included here on the right hand side.

If you have a very mathematical report, then you may wish to divide the nomenclature list into functions and variables, and then sub- and super-scripts.

If you have a large number of acronyms, check out to make that more robust.

Note that Roman mathematical symbols are typically in a serif font in italics.

1 Introduction

1.1 Research Background

Artificial intelligence (AI) has become a major force in contemporary marketing. Across digital platforms, firms now use AI to support recommendation systems, personalised advertising, customer segmentation, predictive analytics, chatbots, and automated decision-making. Recent scholarship suggests that AI is no longer a peripheral tool used only for back-end optimisation; instead, it increasingly shapes how brands communicate with consumers, how marketing decisions are made, and how value is created in the marketplace [1–3].

The rapid diffusion of generative artificial intelligence (GenAI) has intensified this transformation. In contrast to earlier forms of predictive AI, which primarily supported classification, targeting, and forecasting, GenAI can directly produce marketing content such as text, images, product descriptions, promotional copy, and interactive brand messages. As a result, AI is no longer only involved in analysing consumer data; it is also participating in the creation of the marketing message itself [4, 5]. This development raises new questions about whether consumers interpret AI-mediated communication in the same way as human-created communication.

From a marketing perspective, this shift matters because consumer responses are not determined solely by functional efficiency. Consumers also evaluate whether a message seems trustworthy, authentic, relevant, credible, intrusive, or helpful. These judgments shape broader outcomes such as attitudes towards the brand, willingness to engage, and purchase intention. Although AI can improve convenience and personalisation, its use may simultaneously generate unease when consumers perceive automation as impersonal, deceptive, or overly dependent on personal data [2, 6]. Understanding consumer perception is therefore central to understanding the broader consequences of AI adoption in marketing.

1.2 Research Problem

The use of AI in marketing presents a tension between commercial opportunity and consumer acceptance. On the one hand, AI promises improved efficiency, scalability, and relevance. Personalised recommendations, automated customer support, and AI-generated promotional content can make marketing more responsive to consumer needs and organisational goals. On the other hand, these same practices may trigger concerns about privacy, transparency, manipulation, authenticity, and the erosion of human connection in brand communication [4, 5].

This tension becomes particularly visible in studies of AI-generated and AI-disclosed marketing content. Emerging empirical work shows that consumers often respond differently when they know a message, image, or advertisement has been created by AI rather than by a human. For example, emotional marketing communication attributed to AI can reduce perceived authenticity and weaken favourable consumer responses [7]. Similarly, disclosure labels can increase novelty while also decreasing authenticity, producing mixed effects on attitudes and purchase intention [8]. Studies on AI-generated advertising and visual content also suggest that trust and purchase intention may decline when AI authorship is salient, especially in high-involvement or emotionally sensitive contexts [9–11].

At the same time, not all findings are negative. Research on AI-powered personalisation indicates that relevance, usefulness, and trust can mediate positive consumer responses, particularly when AI applications are perceived as valuable rather than merely automated [12, 13]. This suggests that consumer perception of AI marketing is neither uniformly positive nor uniformly negative. Instead, it appears to depend on a set of interconnected perceptual dimensions that operate differently across contexts, content types, and degrees of AI visibility.

Despite growing interest in this area, the literature remains fragmented. Existing studies often examine trust, authenticity, privacy, usefulness, or purchase intention as separate issues, and many focus on specific applications such as AI-generated advertising, recommendation systems, or disclosure labels. As a result, there is still a need for a more integrated account of how AI and GenAI influence consumer perception across marketing contexts. This dissertation addresses that need by synthesising the literature through a thematic review focused explicitly on the consumer perspective.

1.3 Research Aim

The aim of this dissertation is to examine how artificial intelligence and generative artificial intelligence influence consumer perception in marketing contexts.

1.4 Research Objectives

1. To review academic literature on AI and generative AI in marketing.
2. To identify the main consumer perception themes that recur across this literature.
3. To analyse how themes such as trust, authenticity, personalisation, privacy concerns, and perceived usefulness shape consumer responses to AI-driven marketing.
4. To develop a thematic understanding of the opportunities and tensions created by AI-mediated marketing communication.

1.5 Research Questions

1. How does existing literature describe the influence of AI and generative AI on consumer perception in marketing?
2. What recurring themes appear in consumer responses to AI-driven marketing practices?
3. How do trust, authenticity, personalisation, privacy concerns, and perceived usefulness shape consumer attitudes and behavioural intentions towards AI marketing?

1.6 Significance of the Study

This study is significant for both academic and practical reasons. Academically, it contributes to a developing body of literature at the intersection of AI, consumer behaviour, and marketing communication. While research on AI in marketing has expanded rapidly, the consumer perspective remains conceptually dispersed across different applications and theoretical lenses [3, 5]. By bringing together literature on predictive AI, generative AI, advertising, personalisation, and disclosure, this dissertation offers a clearer account of the perceptual mechanisms that shape consumer responses.

Practically, the study is relevant for marketers and organisations that are increasingly incorporating AI into customer-facing activities. Businesses may assume that efficiency and innovation automatically improve consumer evaluations, yet the literature suggests that acceptance depends on how consumers interpret the meaning of AI use. If AI-generated content is seen as useful and relevant, it may strengthen engagement and purchase intention; if it is seen as inauthentic, misleading, or invasive, it may damage trust and brand relationships [7, 9, 12]. A better understanding of these dynamics can help organisations deploy AI more responsibly and strategically.

1.7 Scope of the Study

This dissertation focuses on consumer perception in marketing rather than on the technical performance of AI systems. It examines literature on AI-enabled marketing practices including personalised advertising, recommendation systems, AI-generated advertising content, chatbots, and social media communication. The study considers both traditional predictive AI and newer forms of generative AI, especially where AI becomes visible in the marketing message or consumer experience.

The dissertation is limited to secondary research and does not involve primary data collection. Its purpose is not to test causal relationships empirically, but to synthesise and interpret existing academic evidence. The emphasis is therefore on identifying recurring themes, tensions, and patterns in the literature rather than on evaluating the engineering performance of AI technologies.

1.8 Dissertation Structure

This dissertation is organised into five chapters. Chapter 1 introduces the research background, problem, aim, objectives, research questions, and scope of the study. Chapter 2 reviews the literature on AI, generative AI, and consumer perception in marketing, and develops the conceptual basis for the study. Chapter 3 explains the methodology, including the literature selection process and thematic analysis approach. Chapter 4 presents and discusses the main themes identified from the reviewed literature. Chapter 5 concludes the dissertation by summarising the findings, outlining the implications of the study, and suggesting directions for future research.

2 Literature Review

2.1 Introduction

This chapter reviews the academic literature on artificial intelligence (AI), generative artificial intelligence (GenAI), and consumer perception in marketing. Its purpose is twofold. First, it establishes the conceptual background needed to understand how AI has evolved from a back-end analytical tool into a visible actor in marketing communication. Second, it identifies the major perceptual themes that recur across existing studies and that are most relevant to this dissertation, namely trust, authenticity, personalisation, privacy concerns, and purchase intention.

The literature on AI in marketing has grown rapidly, but it remains uneven in focus. Some studies examine AI as an organisational capability that improves targeting, automation, and decision-making, while others examine specific consumer reactions to AI-generated advertising, disclosure labels, recommendation systems, or social media interactions [1–3]. This chapter therefore brings these strands together in order to build a coherent foundation for the thematic analysis presented later in the dissertation.

2.2 Artificial Intelligence in Marketing

AI has become deeply embedded in marketing practice. Earlier research often emphasised its role in data analysis, forecasting, customer segmentation, and optimisation, particularly in areas such as recommendation systems, programmatic advertising, customer relationship management, and service automation [1, 3]. In this sense, AI initially developed as a functional and predictive tool that helped organisations process large quantities of consumer data more efficiently than traditional methods.

More recent research argues that AI should not be understood only as a technological add-on, but as a force that reshapes marketing strategy, customer experience, and market interaction [2, 6]. Kumar et al. highlight that AI now affects multiple marketing functions, including customer insights, campaign performance, strategic automation, and engagement design, while also raising ethical and privacy-related concerns [2]. Similarly, Mohd Amin et

al. argue that AI adoption is transforming not only operational efficiency but also the broader relationship between firms and consumers, especially where predictive analytics and personalised experiences become central to value creation [6].

This shift matters because marketing is not simply about efficient delivery. It is also about meaning, persuasion, credibility, and relational exchange. As AI becomes more visible in customer-facing communication, consumers are no longer responding only to products or brands; they are also responding to the presence of algorithmic systems within the communication process itself.

2.3 From Predictive AI to Generative AI

The emergence of GenAI marks a major shift in this literature. Hermann and Puntoni distinguish between earlier forms of predictive or decision-oriented AI and newer generative systems capable of producing text, images, and other forms of content that directly shape consumer experience [4]. This distinction is especially important for marketing because it changes the role AI plays. Predictive AI largely supports marketers behind the scenes, whereas GenAI increasingly participates in the visible construction of advertisements, branded messages, product information, and platform interactions.

GenAI therefore introduces a different type of consumer question. Consumers may accept algorithmic systems when they improve convenience or recommendation accuracy, yet they may react differently when AI appears to replace human creativity, judgment, or emotional communication. Ubal et al. argue that consumer responses to AI are shaped not only by the technological system itself but also by contextual and psychological factors that influence whether AI is perceived as helpful, competent, human-like, or socially appropriate [5]. This makes GenAI particularly important for a dissertation concerned with perception, because it sits at the boundary between efficiency and symbolic meaning.

2.4 Consumer Perception as a Conceptual Lens

Consumer perception refers to the process through which individuals interpret, evaluate, and respond to marketplace stimuli. Within the context of AI marketing, this concept is especially useful because it moves attention away from technical capability alone and towards how consumers make sense of AI-mediated experiences. In other words, the key question is not simply what AI can do, but how consumers interpret its presence, outputs, and intentions.

Existing reviews suggest that AI-consumer interaction is shaped by multiple perceptual dimensions rather than a single evaluation criterion [4,5]. Consumers may perceive AI as

efficient, data-driven, and useful, yet also impersonal, opaque, or intrusive. These conflicting interpretations help explain why responses to AI in marketing are often mixed rather than consistently favourable or unfavourable. The literature therefore points towards a multidimensional view of consumer perception in which trust, authenticity, relevance, privacy, and behavioural intention interact rather than operate independently.

2.5 Key Themes in AI Marketing and Consumer Perception

2.5.1 Trust and Credibility

Trust is one of the most frequently discussed themes in the literature on AI in marketing. In broad terms, trust concerns whether consumers believe that an AI-enabled system or AI-mediated message is reliable, competent, and aligned with their interests. Studies on AI-powered personalisation show that trust often functions as a central mediating variable between technological capability and positive consumer response. For example, An and Ngo find that perceived relevance and usefulness strengthen trust in AI-powered personalised advertising, which in turn supports purchase intention [12].

At the same time, trust is fragile when consumers perceive AI as lacking transparency or social understanding. Research on AI-generated advertising suggests that consumer trust can decline when AI authorship becomes explicit, particularly in higher-involvement purchase contexts [9]. Similarly, in social media environments, Srivastava and Gurme show that trust remains a crucial factor linking perceived personalisation to favourable consumer outcomes, even as privacy concerns exert a negative counterweight [13]. Taken together, these studies suggest that trust does not arise automatically from technological sophistication; it must be supported by perceived value, clarity, and legitimacy.

2.5.2 Authenticity

Authenticity has become especially important in the GenAI literature because AI-generated content often raises questions about sincerity, originality, and human presence. This is particularly significant in marketing communication, where consumers may evaluate not only the informational content of a message but also whether it feels genuine or socially appropriate.

Kirk and Givi provide strong evidence for what they term the “AI-authorship effect”, showing that when emotional marketing communication is believed to be written by AI rather than a human, consumers respond less favourably because perceived authenticity declines [7]. Relatedly, Shi and Jiang show that AI disclosure labels can create a dual effect: they

increase novelty, but they also weaken authenticity, which can reduce attitudes and purchase intention depending on the consumer and product type [8]. These findings suggest that authenticity is not a minor aesthetic issue but a central perceptual mechanism through which consumers judge AI-generated communication.

2.5.3 Personalisation, Relevance, and Usefulness

One of the strongest arguments in favour of AI marketing is its ability to deliver highly personalised experiences. Personalisation can increase the perceived relevance of content, reduce search effort, and create a stronger sense that a brand understands consumer needs. This theme appears consistently across both conceptual and empirical studies [1, 2].

However, the literature also shows that personalisation is not inherently positive. Its effect depends on whether consumers interpret tailored content as genuinely useful or as evidence of excessive surveillance and standardisation. An and Ngo demonstrate that personalisation strengthens purchase intention when it enhances relevance and usefulness, rather than when it simply signals technological sophistication [12]. This reinforces the broader argument that perceived value, rather than automation alone, determines whether personalisation contributes positively to consumer perception.

2.5.4 Privacy Concerns

Privacy concerns remain one of the most persistent tensions in the literature on AI marketing. Because many AI applications depend on large volumes of personal and behavioural data, consumers may feel uneasy about tracking, monitoring, profiling, or opaque data use. This concern is especially visible in personalised advertising and social media environments, where the boundary between convenience and surveillance may become blurred.

Conceptual work on AI marketing regularly identifies privacy as a core challenge to long-term consumer acceptance [2, 6]. Empirical evidence supports this concern. Srivastava and Gurme find that privacy concerns directly weaken positive responses to AI-mediated consumer engagement on social media, even where personalisation and trust remain important [13]. Privacy therefore operates not only as an ethical issue but also as a perceptual barrier that can undermine otherwise effective AI marketing practices.

2.5.5 Purchase Intention and Behavioural Outcomes

Ultimately, many studies connect consumer perception to behavioural outcomes such as purchase intention, engagement, recommendation, and loyalty. This is important because it shows that perceptual themes are not merely abstract attitudes; they shape practical market

responses.

Research in this area suggests that AI can improve behavioural outcomes when consumers perceive its use as relevant, useful, or efficient, but these positive effects can be reversed when AI reduces authenticity or trust [7, 12]. Studies of AI-generated advertising images similarly show that attitudes, trust, and purchase intention are highly context-dependent. Belanche et al. find that real images are often preferred over GenAI images in high-involvement and hedonic service settings, while Zhang and Hur show that consumer response can vary depending on whether the motivation for AI use is disclosed as privacy protection, visual appeal, or cost efficiency [10, 11]. These findings indicate that behavioural outcomes are best understood as the result of interacting perceptual mechanisms rather than as direct effects of AI use alone.

2.6 Synthesis and Research Gap

Taken together, the literature suggests that AI in marketing operates through a set of interrelated perceptual tensions. AI can improve convenience, relevance, and usefulness, but it can also reduce authenticity, weaken trust, and intensify privacy concerns. These tensions are especially pronounced in GenAI contexts, where AI becomes visible as a creator of marketing content rather than merely a hidden analytical system.

Despite the rapid expansion of this field, several gaps remain. First, the literature is still fragmented across specific applications such as advertising, social media, personalised recommendation, or disclosure labels. Second, many studies isolate a single construct, such as trust or authenticity, without fully explaining how these themes interact. Third, conceptual and review-based research often identify broad trends in AI marketing, while empirical studies focus on narrow scenarios, making it difficult to draw an integrated consumer-centred picture [3, 5]. This dissertation responds to these gaps by adopting a thematic literature review that synthesises the main recurring dimensions of consumer perception across AI and GenAI marketing studies.

2.7 Summary

This chapter has reviewed the literature on AI and GenAI in marketing from a consumer perception perspective. It has shown that AI marketing cannot be evaluated solely in terms of efficiency or innovation. Instead, consumer responses are shaped by interacting themes including trust, authenticity, personalisation, privacy concerns, and purchase intention. These themes form the conceptual basis for the methodology and thematic analysis developed in the following chapters.

3 Methodology

3.1 Research Approach

This study adopts a qualitative research approach based on a literature review. Rather than collecting primary data, the research focuses on analysing existing academic studies related to artificial intelligence (AI), generative AI, and consumer perception in marketing.

3.2 Research Design

The study uses thematic analysis to identify patterns and themes across selected academic literature. This approach allows the research to organise and interpret complex findings from multiple sources.

3.3 Data Collection

The data for this study consists of academic journal articles related to AI in marketing and consumer perception. These articles were selected using academic databases such as Google Scholar, Scopus, and ScienceDirect.

Keywords used for searching include:

- Artificial intelligence in marketing
- Generative AI advertising
- Consumer perception AI
- AI-generated content
- AI trust, authenticity, and privacy

3.4 Data Selection Criteria

To ensure relevance and quality, the following criteria were applied:

- Peer-reviewed journal articles
- Published between 2020 and 2025
- Focus on AI or generative AI in marketing
- Discuss consumer perception or related concepts

A total of approximately 15–25 articles were selected for detailed analysis.

3.5 Thematic Analysis

Thematic analysis was used to identify key themes across the selected literature. The process followed several steps:

1. Familiarisation with the data through reading the articles
2. Initial coding of key concepts and findings
3. Grouping codes into broader themes
4. Reviewing and refining themes

Key themes identified include trust, authenticity, personalisation, privacy concerns, and purchase intention.

3.6 Limitations

This study has several limitations. First, it relies only on secondary data, which may limit the depth of analysis. Second, the selection of literature may introduce bias. Third, the findings are based on interpretation and may not represent all consumer perspectives.

3.7 Summary

This chapter has outlined the research approach, data collection process, and analytical method used in this study. The next chapter presents the findings based on thematic analysis.

4 Findings and Discussion

4.1 Introduction

This chapter presents the findings from the thematic analysis of the selected literature. It identifies key themes related to consumer perception in AI-driven marketing and discusses how these themes interact.

4.2 Overview of Identified Themes

The analysis revealed five main themes:

- Trust
- Authenticity
- Personalisation
- Privacy Concerns
- Purchase Intention

These themes represent the most common patterns found across the selected studies.

4.3 Trust

Trust is one of the most frequently discussed themes in AI marketing literature. Many studies suggest that AI can both increase and decrease consumer trust.

On one hand, AI systems are often perceived as efficient and data-driven, which can enhance trust. On the other hand, the lack of transparency and human involvement may reduce trust, especially when consumers are aware that content is generated by AI.

4.4 Authenticity

Authenticity is closely related to how consumers evaluate AI-generated content. Several studies indicate that AI-generated messages may be perceived as less authentic, particularly in emotional or human-centred communication.

This effect becomes stronger when consumers are informed that the content is created by AI. As a result, authenticity plays a key role in shaping consumer attitudes.

4.5 Personalisation

AI enables a high level of personalisation in marketing. Personalised recommendations and targeted advertising can improve relevance and user experience.

However, excessive personalisation may also lead to discomfort, especially when consumers feel that their data is being overly monitored.

4.6 Privacy Concerns

Privacy concerns are a major issue in AI-driven marketing. Consumers may worry about how their personal data is collected and used.

These concerns can negatively influence trust and reduce the effectiveness of AI-based marketing strategies.

4.7 Purchase Intention

AI influences consumer decision-making through recommendation systems and targeted communication.

When consumers perceive AI as useful and trustworthy, purchase intention tends to increase. However, negative perceptions related to authenticity or privacy may reduce willingness to purchase.

4.8 Interrelationship Between Themes

The findings suggest that these themes are interconnected. For example:

- Lower authenticity can reduce trust
- Privacy concerns can weaken the positive effects of personalisation

- Trust plays a central role in determining purchase intention

This indicates that consumer perception in AI marketing is not influenced by a single factor, but by the interaction of multiple themes.

4.9 Discussion

The findings align with existing literature that highlights both the benefits and risks of AI in marketing. While AI improves efficiency and personalisation, it also introduces challenges related to trust, authenticity, and privacy.

This supports the idea that AI marketing involves a trade-off. Consumers may accept AI-driven services if the perceived benefits outweigh the risks.

4.10 Summary

This chapter has presented the main findings from the thematic analysis. It has shown that consumer perception is shaped by multiple interconnected factors. The next chapter will conclude the study and discuss implications and future research.

5 Conclusion

5.1 Introduction

This chapter summarises the key findings of the study, discusses theoretical and practical implications, and outlines limitations and directions for future research.

5.2 Summary of Findings

This dissertation examined how artificial intelligence (AI) and generative AI influence consumer perception in marketing. Through a thematic analysis of existing literature, five key themes were identified: trust, authenticity, personalisation, privacy concerns, and purchase intention.

The findings suggest that AI has a dual impact on consumer perception. On one hand, AI improves efficiency, relevance, and personalisation in marketing. On the other hand, it raises concerns related to authenticity, transparency, and privacy. These conflicting effects indicate that AI-driven marketing involves a trade-off between benefits and risks.

Trust was found to be a central factor linking all other themes. Consumers are more likely to accept AI-driven marketing when they perceive it as trustworthy and useful. However, when authenticity is questioned or privacy concerns arise, trust may decrease, leading to lower purchase intention.

5.3 Theoretical Implications

This study contributes to the literature by integrating research on AI in marketing with consumer perception theories. It highlights the importance of examining multiple interconnected factors rather than focusing on a single variable.

In particular, the study emphasises the role of authenticity and trust in shaping consumer responses to AI-generated content. It also extends existing research by considering generative AI as a distinct category that directly influences marketing communication.

5.4 Practical Implications

From a practical perspective, the findings suggest that marketers should carefully balance the use of AI technologies with consumer expectations.

First, transparency is important. Clearly communicating the use of AI may help reduce uncertainty and increase trust.

Second, firms should ensure that AI-generated content maintains a level of authenticity, especially in emotional or human-centred communication.

Third, data usage should be managed responsibly to reduce privacy concerns and build long-term consumer trust.

5.5 Limitations

This study has several limitations. It relies on secondary data and does not include primary empirical research. The selection of literature may also introduce bias, as only a limited number of studies were analysed.

In addition, the findings are based on interpretation and may not fully capture the diversity of consumer experiences across different cultural and market contexts.

5.6 Future Research

Future research could address these limitations by conducting empirical studies, such as surveys or experiments, to test the relationships identified in this study.

Further research is also needed to explore how different types of AI applications influence consumer perception in various contexts. In particular, the impact of generative AI on authenticity and trust remains an important area for investigation.

5.7 Final Remarks

Artificial intelligence and generative AI are transforming the marketing landscape. While they offer significant opportunities for improving efficiency and personalisation, they also introduce new challenges for consumer perception.

Understanding how consumers respond to AI-driven marketing is therefore essential for both researchers and practitioners. This study provides a foundation for future research in this evolving field.

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A1 Appendix

You may use appendices to include relevant background information, such as calibration certificates, derivations of key equations or presentation of a particular data reduction method. You should not use the appendices to dump large amounts of additional results or data which are not properly discussed. If these results are really relevant, then they should appear in the main body of the report.

A1.1 Appendix numbering

Appendices are numbered sequentially, A1, A2, A3. . . The sections, figures and tables within appendices are numbered in the same way as in the main text. For example, the first figure in Appendix A1 would be Figure A1.1. Equations continue the numbering from the main text.